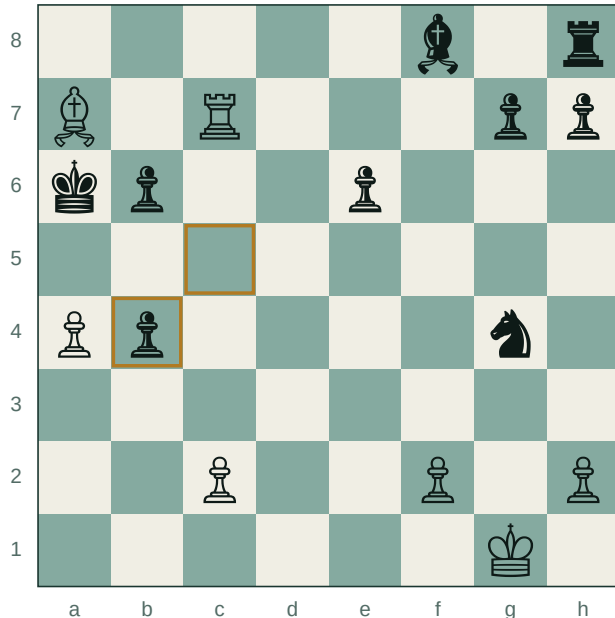


Clearance tactics: White, move 25

Clearance tactics

White to move



Previous move: 24...cxb4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

25. Bb8 b5 26. Ra7+ Kb6 27. a5+ Kc5 28. Rc7+

25.Bb8 The bishop moves from a7 to b8. Recorded reply: **25...b5**.

26.Ra7+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. Recorded reply: **26...Kb6**.

27.a5+ Check restricts Black to 2 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **27...Kc5**.

28.Rc7+ Check restricts Black to 3 legal replies here.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 16 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +0. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +0: the balance goes from -4 to -4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on a6. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and knight on g4. Check for tactical protection.